

Brand Association



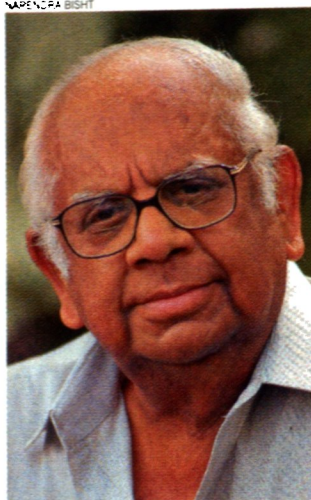
Celebrity endorsements are now so ubiquitous that it's becoming difficult to tell the wheat from the chapati. Market gurus tell us that celebrity endorsements work but now there's a new twist in the tail. Recent ads for

Louis Vuitton use Mikhail Gorbachev, former Soviet leader, while Bill Clinton has an Audemars Piguet watch named after him. The difference is that the money earned from their endorsements goes to charities. I would give up Diet Coke if any of our sports or Bollywood stars donated their endorsement earnings to the Missionaries of Charity. Brand endorsements by political leaders do throw up some interesting possibilities. Which product would Prime Minister Manmohan Singh endorse? The Carrier split air-conditioner? It sells itself as being super quiet and whisper soft and staying cool in the most heated situations. The split version is something that is his signature working style under a coalition, plus Carrier is an apt brand name and job description for him considering that (a) it is an American brand, (b) he is often carrying out orders from above, and (c) the machine comes with a hand-held remote.

So where does that leave his serial stalker, Prakash Karat? Red Bull would seem the most appropriate being both bull-headed on the nuclear deal and the very large bull in the Congress China shop, though the comrade would hate the idea of an energy drink that has its maximum sales in America. Sonia Gandhi ideally would be endorsing a brand of Italian spaghetti considering her origins and the state of the party she presides over but a product more suited to her role would be a mixer-grinder considering that she is the ultimate multi-tasker from handling the party to advising the government, managing the coalition and grooming her son and heir to take over the family business. Mayawati is easy—either a jewellery brand with diamonds as its USP or a real estate major considering the vast area she controls in political and property terms. Karunanidhi could only endorse a brand of dark glasses while Sharad Pawar, in his BCCI avatar, would be a perfect fit for Boss. Home Minister Shivraj Patel is better at promoting designer external wear than in tackling internal security, while Narendra Modi is ideal for All Out which gets rid of all undesirable insects and lesser creatures. As a post script, how about this: the only politician in India to ever appear in a commercial advertising campaign was Maneka Gandhi, who was shown wrapped in a towel and little else, which pretty much describes her current political status.



NARENDRA BISHT



IN TANDEM: Chatterjee (left) and Katju think alike

Judiciously Speaking

DELHI It is difficult to guess how long it has been going on, but Somnath Chatterjee and at least two justices of the Supreme Court seem to think and even write alike. A speech delivered by the Lok Sabha speaker in April this year on "Separation of powers and Judicial Activism in India" has provided so much inspiration to Justices A.K. Mathur and Markandey Katju of the apex court so much so that they used verbatim large chunks of the speech in a judgement delivered in early December.

In his speech, Chatterjee had criticised courts for over-reaching themselves and straying into the executive domain in matters of policy. The specific instances which the speaker had mentioned were the same ones that the two judges also referred to while criticising their fellow judges and those from the lower courts for exceeding their powers.

An example. On April 26, Chatterjee said in his speech, "...orders passed by the hon'ble high court

of Delhi in recent times dealt with subjects ranging from age and other criteria for nursery admissions, unauthorised schools, number of free beds in hospitals on public land, use and misuse of ambulances... the kind of air Delhiites breathe, begging in public, the use of subways, nature of buses we board, the legality of constructions in Delhi..."

On December 6, the two judges in their judgement virtually reproduced the entire paragraph. "Orders passed by the Hon'ble High Court of Delhi in recent times dealt with subjects ranging from age and other criteria for nursery admissions, unauthorised schools... number of free beds in hospitals on public land, use and misuse of ambulances... the kind of air Delhiites breathe, begging in public, the use of subways, nature of buses we board, the legality of constructions in Delhi..."

It is seldom that two arms of the republic think in such perfect harmony.

by Rahul Tewari